

Nobody Started Liking Their Own Side More

Forty-six years of feeling thermometers, the half of the gap that moved, and the two numbers that are not temperatures

84-355 Democracy's Data

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Every two years since 1978, the American National Election Studies has asked people to rate the two parties on a thermometer. A hundred is warm, nought is cold, fifty is neither.

Subtract a partisan's rating of the other party from their rating of their own. That is the standard measure of **affective polarization**: not how far apart the parties are on policy, but how much more warmly people feel toward their own side. That number has more than doubled, from 22.6 degrees in 1978 to 49.5 in 2024.

It is a difference, so it has two halves. They did not do the same thing.

01 Before you read on

In 1978, partisans rated their own party 70.6 degrees and the other party 48.0.

By 2024, what had each of those become? Write down both.

Two numbers again. The interesting one is the first.

02 The file, and the door in front of it

This is the ANES Time Series Cumulative Data File: 73,745 respondents interviewed between 1948 and 2024, 1,030 variables, 156 MB.

It is free, and it cannot be downloaded by a script. ANES requires an account and agreement to terms, and hands the file only to a logged-in browser. So this chapter's source arrived the way `ga-precinct-returns` and the media chapters' did, by a person clicking a button. It is preserved in `raw/` rather than discarded, so nobody has to click it twice.

Set that against the GSS chapters, whose file any script can fetch. Same kind of survey, same kind of question, different answer to "can you have it". The survey access chapter measures those doors directly.

03 Two numbers in this column are not temperatures

Before any average, the trap.

The scale everybody describes as nought to a hundred is coded **0 to 97** in this file. There is no value of 100 anywhere in it: 0 respondents in 73,745 were recorded at a hundred degrees, because a hundred is not a code the file uses.

What it does use is 98 for *don't know* and 99 for *not ascertained*. 2,183 and 934 entries carry them.

Nothing about that is hidden, and nothing about it is visible either. A 98 sits inside the range a reader expects, so it does not look wrong. It looks like somebody who feels very warmly indeed.

Believe them and the country warms by 1.4 degrees: the average rating goes from 51.5 to 53.0. Worse than the offset is that the codes are not evenly spread across years, so the error moves the trend rather than shifting it.

Everything below drops them, along with 20 negative codes.

04 The scale is coarser than it looks

The thermometer offers 98 positions. People use about four.

Rating	Share of all ratings
0 — as cold as possible	10.1%
50 — the midpoint	16.1%
85	10.5%
97 — the top of the scale	6.6%

70.7% of all 97,268 ratings are multiples of ten. The 85s are the tell that this is habit rather than measurement: nobody feels 85 degrees about a political party, but it is where the hand goes when the answer is “warm, not the maximum”.

A number that fine-grained, used that coarsely, still averages perfectly well. It just does not mean what its precision suggests.

05 The two halves

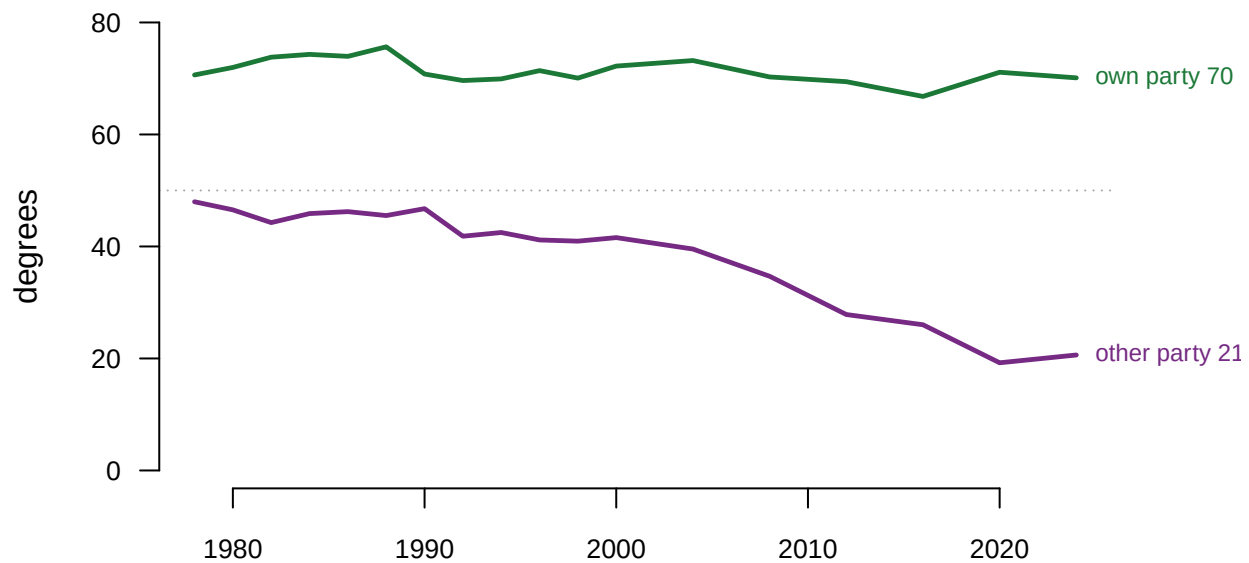


Figure 1. Warmth toward one's own party and toward the other, among partisans including leaners, 1978 to 2024. In the browser, the buttons swap between the halves and the gap they produce.

The green line does not move. Partisans rated their own party 70.6 degrees in 1978 and 70.1 in 2024, a change of 0.5 of a degree across forty-six years.

The purple line falls off the table. Warmth toward the other party went from 48.0 to 20.6, a drop of 27.4 degrees, and it is now well below the point the scale calls cold.

98.1% of the movement in the gap is the out-party half. Nobody started liking their own side more. They stopped being able to stand the other one.

06 Where the coldness went

The averages hide how it happened, and it is not everybody sliding down a few degrees.

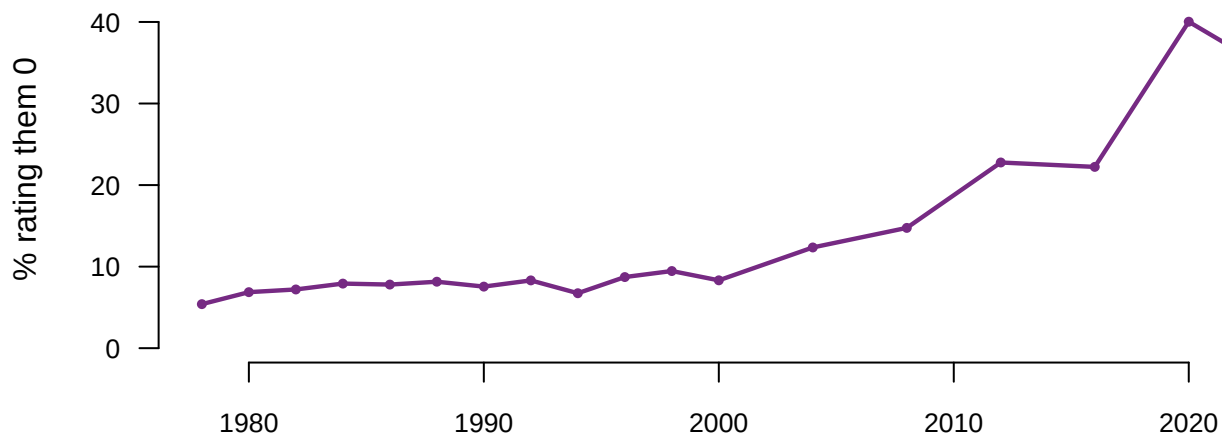


Figure 2. The share of partisans rating the other party at absolute zero.

In 1978, 5.4% of partisans gave the other party the coldest rating available. In 2024 it was 33.2%.

That is a third of partisans choosing the bottom of the scale. The average fell partly because a large group stopped using the scale at all and went to its floor.

07 What this chapter cannot tell you

A thermometer reading is not a behaviour. It is a number somebody said to an interviewer. Nothing here shows anyone acting on it, and the literature linking affective polarization to behaviour is contested.

The parties being rated changed. “The Republican Party” meant something different in 1978 than in 2024, and a respondent rating it coldly may be rating a different object rather than feeling differently about the same one.

These are cross-sections. Different people every year. A series can fall because individuals changed or because the population changed underneath it, and this cannot separate those.

Leaners are counted as partisans, which is the standard choice and is a choice: see party identification, where it moves a headline number by a factor of five. Pure independents, 5,327 of them, have no own party and are absent from every figure here.

And a year needs 200 respondents to appear. That leaves 18 study years between 1978 and 2024, so the lines connect points several years apart and the connecting segments are drawn, not measured.

08 What it does establish

Affective polarization in the ANES is 49.5 degrees, up from 22.6, and it peaked at 51.9 in 2020.

Essentially all of that is one half. Warmth toward one’s own party moved 0.5 of a degree in forty-six years. Warmth toward the other party fell 27.4, and the share of partisans choosing absolute zero went from 5.4% to 33.2%.

The single number that gets reported cannot show any of that, because a difference has no memory of which side moved. This book keeps meeting that shape: the gender gap is the same arithmetic on a different question, and it has the same answer.

09 Sources

- **American National Election Studies**, Time Series Cumulative Data File 1948-2024, CSV distribution `anes_timeseries_cdf_csv_20260205.csv`. 73,745 respondents. Variables VCF0218 and VCF0224 are the two party thermometers, VCF0301 party identification, VCF0009z the weight. <https://electionstudies.org/data-center/anes-time-series-cumulative-data-file/>
- **Not scriptable.** ANES serves the file only to a logged-in account holder. It is preserved in `../anes/data/raw/`, which this chapter reads rather than keeping a second 156 MB copy.

- **Codebooks** are kept beside the data. The meaning of codes 98 and 99 was read out of them rather than assumed.
- **Build.** `data/build-data.R` reads five columns, drops the codes that are not temperatures, and writes the three tables this chapter reads. Every number above is computed at the moment this document was rendered.

Checks

The data itself

Every figure above is drawn from these tables. They are plain CSV, they open in a spreadsheet, and they are yours to take further.

`out_party_zero.csv`, `thermometers_by_year.csv`

Your turn

None of these is answered above, and every one can be answered from the tables you just opened.

- `thermometers_by_year.csv` keeps `in_party` and `out_party` as separate columns beside the gap. Plot all three. Which line moved, and does the usual story about polarisation survive it?
- `out_party_zero.csv` counts the people who rated the other side at the bottom of the scale. Follow it across the years. Is the gap widening, or is one tail getting heavier?
- A thermometer runs from cold to warm, but people answer in round numbers. Look at where answers cluster and decide how many distinct values this scale really has.
- `thermometers_by_year.csv` has `n` for every year. Find the thinnest ones, then decide whether the shape of the trend depends on them.

Check	Passed
the whole cumulative file arrived	yes
there is no value of 100 in a column described as running to 100	yes
the codes that masquerade as warmth are present and worth removing	yes
believing the codes warms the country	yes
the scale is used far more coarsely than its 98 points allow	yes
the series spans at least four decades	yes
the gap is wider at the end than at the start	yes
out-party warmth moved further than in-party warmth	yes
rating the other party at absolute zero became far more common	yes